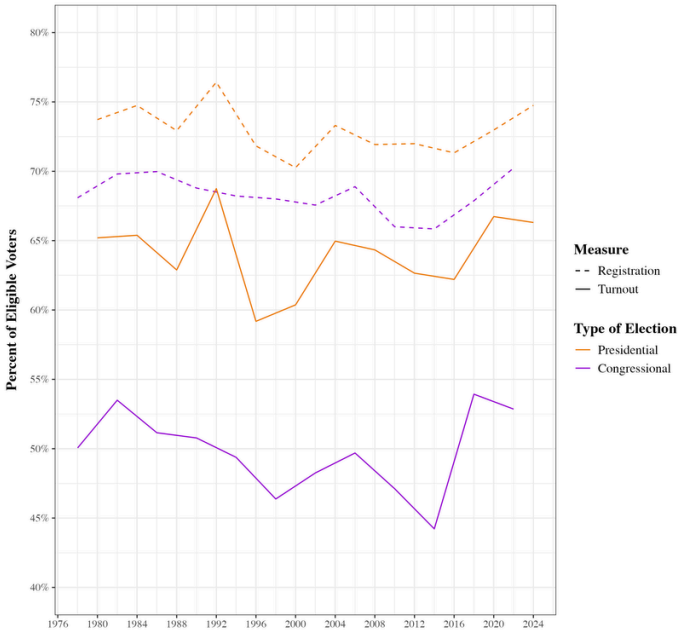


States with Electoral Reform Policies Have More Engaged and Democrat-Leaning Voters

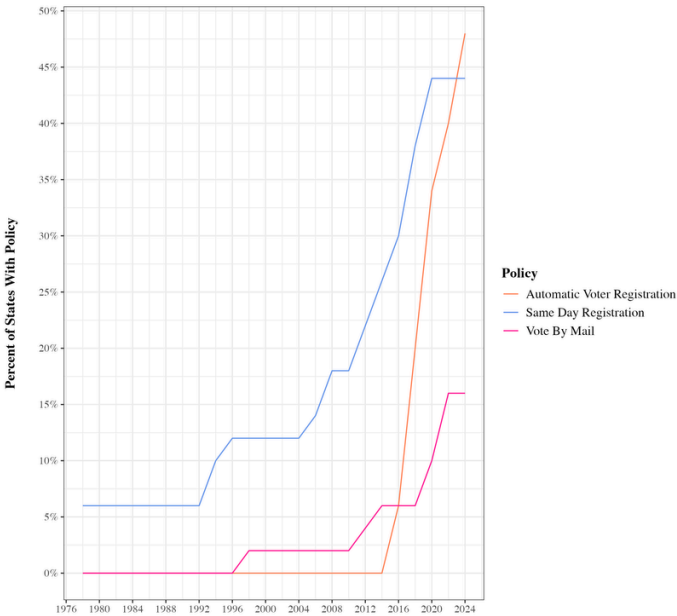
Amelia Johnson

This report visualizes Census Bureau state-level voter registration and turnout data for elections 1978-2024, as well as electoral policy and partisan information from Ballotpedia and 270 to Win. Data were combined by the author in one cohesive dataset which describes the changes in state-level voting trends over time, alongside state adoption of three electoral policies: universal vote by mail, same day registration, and automatic voter registration. Such policies aim to improve registration and turnout rates. States which implemented these policies see higher overall registration and turnout rates and vote more Democratic on average, though these trends are likely symptoms of the underlying partisan and civic characteristics of the state populace, rather than direct effects of election reform.

Voter Registration and Turnout Patterns Remain Fairly Consistent



States Increasingly Adopted Electoral Policies Over Time
Vote By Mail Lags Behind Other Policies



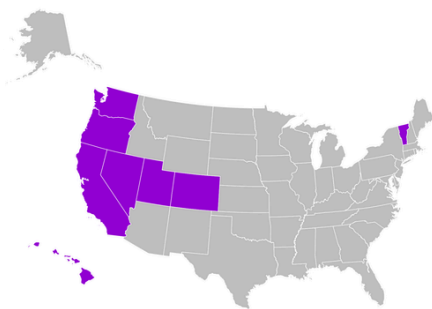
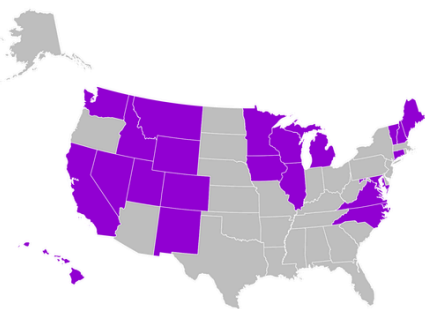
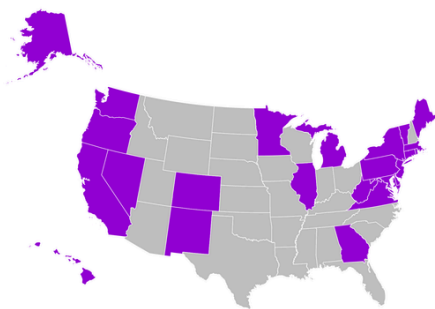
Vote by mail, same day registration, and automatic voter registration became more widespread in the past two decades, though their implementation is asymmetric across states and policies. Overall registration and turnout patterns in the US are relatively stable despite the gradual emergence of election reform efforts, and disagreement among states about which policies should be implemented.

Electoral Policies Differ Across US States, 2024

Automatic Voter Registration

Same Day Registration

Vote By Mail



Policy ■ Implemented ■ Not Implemented

States With Electoral Policies Have Higher Average Registration Levels



States With Electoral Policies Have Higher Average Turnout Levels



Election-by-election, states with electoral policies outperform those without. These policies are not mutually exclusive, so many states may enjoy the benefits of multiple policies simultaneously. States with reform policies also vote more blue than others, suggesting that differences in voting patterns among states may stem from differences in populaces. This association between engaged citizens, Democrat election success, and legislatures' ability to pass voting reform policies shows how citizen-level characteristics and policy decisions combine at the ballot box.

States with Electoral Policies Voted More Democratic in Presidential Elections 1980-2024

